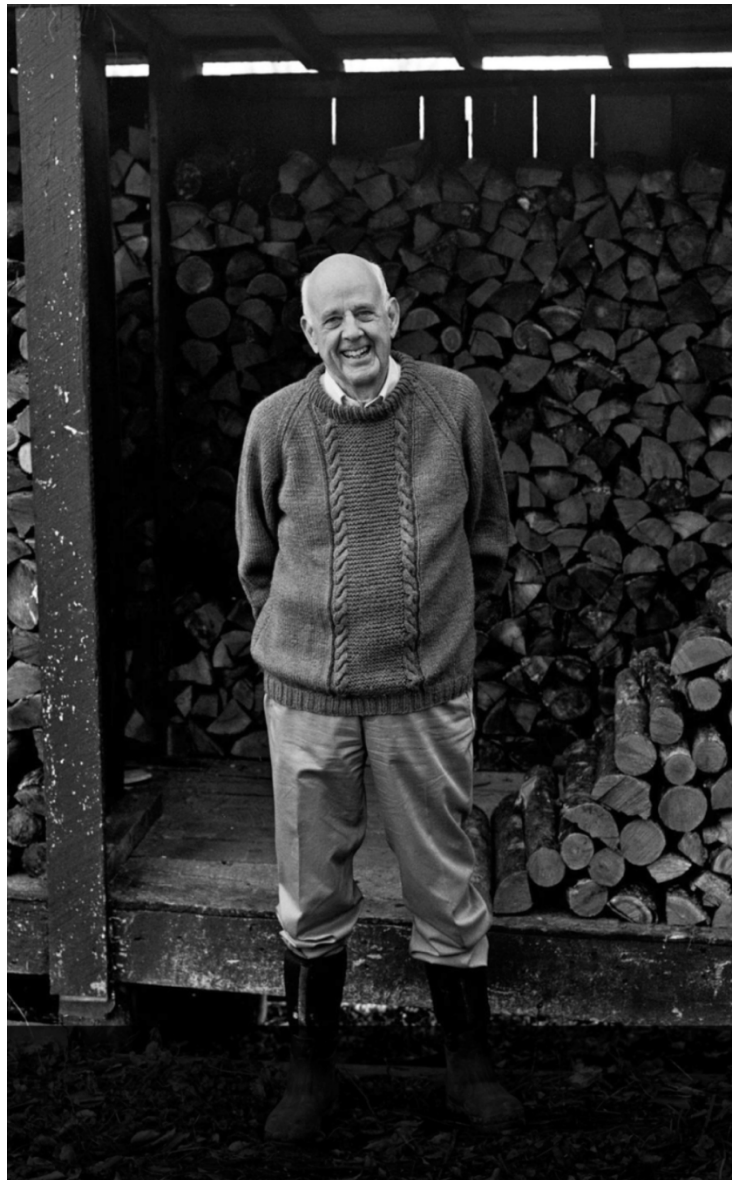


FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*The Gospel of Life ~
The Gospel According to Wendell Berry
September 14th, 2025*



Photographed by Guy Mendes

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on LASST UNS ERFREUEN and FOREST GREEN

Credo in Spiritum Sanctum from *The Mass* (Patrick Cassidy)

Four movements by Giovanni Battista Pergolesi:

- Tempo giusto in Eb Major
- Largo in G minor
- Allegro in Bb Major
- Largo in F minor

Osanna II from *The Mass* (Patrick Cassidy)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Emily Kang & Gavin Gregorio

Gracious God, how can creation sing your praises,
except with the red wings of blackbirds flashing across blue sky,
and the croak and splash of frogs playing hide-and-seek in the ponds?

How can the firmament proclaim your handiwork, except in the
wagging tail of a puppy, and the focused attention of a toddler
soaking in the wonder of it all?

How can the heavens proclaim your glory,
except through a morning sun rising upon gold-green grass,
lighting up the face of lovers as Earth spins them once more into a new day?

Your beauty and goodness, O Immanent One,
requires Earth's diversity and our own wildness,
breaking down – and out of – the monotony of prescribed patterns,
choosing rather to take our place
in the dancing procession of different-ness,
the variegated life of Christ finding expression
in this body of the church and the bodies of our kin-creatures.

*Make a harvest, O Holy One,
of our diversity
that we might be your radiant presence.*

[Uniting Church Canada / adapt]

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

To You, O God, All Creatures Sing

LASST UNS ERFREUEN

To you, O God, all creatures sing,
and all creation, everything
sings your praises, alleluia!
Your burning sun with golden beam,
your silver moon with softer gleam
sing your praises, alleluia,
alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

Your wind that blows the tempest by,
your clouds that sail across the sky
sing your praises, alleluia!
Your morning rises with a song,
and lights of evening sing along,
sing your praises, alleluia,
alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

Your flowing waters, crystal clear,
make melodies for you to hear,
sings your praises, alleluia!
Your fire,...bountiful and bright,
remembering your warmth and light,
sings your praises, alleluia,
alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

To you, O God, day after day,
your planet earth in every way,
sings your praises, alleluia!
As savory fruit and fragrant flower
show forth your glory and your power,
singing praises, alleluia,
alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

-text adapted by Miriam Therese Winter

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Fregin

Creative God,
whose renewing breath fills our planet,
may we discern your vibrant presence among us.
On this day, and in all the days to come,
may our spirits be lifted
as we celebrate the kinship between humanity
and all of your great creation.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"When I Rise Up"
Cathedral Choir

J. DAVID MOORE

*"When I rise up, let me rise up joyful like a bird. When I fall,
let me fall without regret, like a leaf." ~Wendell Berry*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Emily Kang

*Great Spirit, our Creator, who is in all places,
Sacred is your name.
May your wisdom guide us,
Your will be done in our lives, as it is throughout Creation.*

*Provide for us today the nourishment we need,
And forgive us our wrongs, as we forgive those who have wronged us.*

*Lead us on the path of understanding and respect,
And protect us from ignorance and harm.*

*For you are the source of all power, beauty, and love,
From generation to generation, forever and always. Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

When despair for the world grows in me
and I wake in the night at the least sound
in fear of what my life and my children's lives may be,
I go and lie down where the wood drake
rests in his beauty on the water, and the great heron feeds.
I come into the peace of wild things
who do not tax their lives with forethought
of grief. I come into the presence of still water.
And I feel above me the day-blind stars
waiting with their light. For a time
I rest in the grace of the world, and am free.

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition
from Psalms 146 & 147

Emily Kang & Gavin Gregorio

Happy are those whose help is the God of all creation,
who keeps faith forever,

who demands justice for the oppressed,
who gives food to the hungry,
who sets the prisoners free
and opens the eyes of the blind,
who watches over the stranger
and upholds the orphan,
who lifts up those who are broken
and brings down the proud and the wicked.
Praise God in the heavens.
Praise God in the heights.
Praise God, all you angels.
Praise God, sun and moon.

Praise God from the earth,
you sea-monsters and creatures of the deep,
fire and hail, snow and frost, stormy winds and scorching heat,
mountains and hills, fruit trees and towering pines,
wild animals and cattle, creeping things and flying birds,
leaders of the nations and all people,
kings, queens and rulers of the earth.

Let all of them find their voice,
let all of them hear the song,
for God created and we are made.

This is the faith of our ancestors.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Spirit of Creation,
you move in and through us like breath.
When our circumstances feel suffocating, you draw us back into the
rhythms of Life that were before us and will be beyond us.

Rhythms that are slow.
Rhythms that accept times of death and rebirth.
Rhythms that persevere but don't force.
Rhythms that embrace change.

Rhythms that encourage every individual in the direction
of the whole's well being.
Together, every creature and creation, yearning for life.

Every blade of grass breaking through soil,
reaching for the light of the sun.

Every mother bear watching over her cubs day and night,
protecting vulnerable life.
Every saint refusing to compromise on the dignity of your people,
enfleshing radical love.
When our schedules and our machines and our media and our words
make us forget that we are creatures among creation, vulnerable flesh,
beloved parts of a whole,
may we find you again in our inhales and our exhales, pacing our breath
with the spirit of life that has always been pulsing through creation.
May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"The Peace Of Wild Things"
Laude, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Flute*

MICHAEL CONLEY

"When despair for the world grows in me and I wake in the night at the least sound in fear of what my life and my children's lives may be, I go and lie down where the wood drake rests in his beauty on the water, and the great heron feeds. I come into the peace of wild things who do not tax their lives with forethought of grief. I come into the presence of still water. And I feel above me the day-blind stars waiting with their light. For a time I rest in the grace of the world, and am free." ~Wendell Berry

Chancel Conversation

Mary Berry & Rev. Michael Lehman

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

God is the heart of life...

And we are the heartbeat.

May our hearts be filled with thanks and praise and songs of joy.

*We rejoice in the miracle of life
and delight in our participation.*

We give thanks and praise for all that is good in the world.
For that mystery we name God,
for the one named Jesus who came to show us the way,
and for the renewing strength and freedom of the Spirit of Wisdom...

Prayer of Blessing

O Holy One,
Ineffable and yet as near as now.
You are the nameless one,
though named by many traditions.

*You are holy,
you are wholeness,
you are mystery,
the magnificence
that no single tradition can contain.*

Your beauty astounds,
your wisdom clarifies,
your abundance flows out by many rivers
and returns to your ocean heart.

*We honor each river –
veins of tradition,
arteries of life,
returning to your fathomless heart,
and back out again in the body of creation.*

And we are carried away, trusting the flow
that contains all of our many names. [BruceSanguin/adapt]

On this day, and on all the days to come,
help us to remember this meal, the bread of new life
and the cup of hope,
given for each and every one of us.
Amen and Amen.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Lehman & Laurie Dill

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Make Our Garden Grow"
Cathedral Choir

LEONARD BERNSTEIN

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Living God, we join with the earth and each other
to bring new life to the land;
to restore the waters, to refresh the air.

Emily Kang & Gavin Gregorio

*We join with the earth and each other
to renew the day of rest:
to care for the plants, to protect the creatures.*

We join with the earth and each other
to celebrate the seas,
to rejoice in sunlight, to sing the song of the stars.

*We join with the earth and each other
to recreate the human community,
to promote justice and peace, to remember our children.*

We join with the earth and each other.
We join together as diverse expressions of one Loving Mystery;
for the healing of the earth and the renewal of all life.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

I know that I have life
only insofar as I have love.
I have no love
except it come from Thee.
Help me, please, to carry
this candle against the wind. [Wendell Berry]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"More Than Enough"
Cathedral Choir

SUSAN LABARR

*"Growing weather; enough rain; the peach tree bent with its yield; the pasture deep in clover
and grass, enough, and more than enough." ~Wendell Berry*

***Hymn for the Journey**

Creative God, You Spread the Earth

FOREST GREEN

Creative God, you spread the earth with life in many forms:
the deer and elk and columbine, the bee in humming swarms.
Forgive us for each flow'r and bird now vanished by our hand.
Teach us to treat with loving care the creatures of the land.

The planet teemed with living things before all human birth,
and even fire and beasts of prey renewed the life of earth.
Forgive us, that the last to come, we threaten sea and air.
Teach us to tend life's fragile web with wise and tender care.

O playful God, you fill the field with lavender and blue.
You paint the bird with indigo, with red or tawny hue.
Forgive us that we grieve your heart, destroying what you do,
and teach us simpler, gentler ways to live on earth with you.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Amen (Giovanni Battista Pergolesi)

Inside The Music

“So many composers have found inspiration within the music of Wendell Berry’s words. Like other lyrical poets, setting Berry’s poems requires the composer to tap into his lyricism and create a parallel landscape through which the words find new footing. David Moore does this through the use of canon. A lusty melody drawn from America’s diverse full-throated traditions rises up and falls down, mirroring the text’s principle images. Its core energy is that of release through vocalization. Moore gives Berry’s prolonged encouragement to release into nature and life a sonic echo. Michael Conley is a dear friend. His “Appalachian Requiem,” published by Fahad’s See-A-Dot Publishing company, winds its way through questions similar to those often posed by Berry’s writings. The people and places of Appalachia remain a full, often tragic story in American lore. Both Michael’s and my families hail from this region. Our families worked the land, and witnessed the corporate destruction of its vast beauty. They saw the resilience of its people, and their complicated allegiances rooted in hardship. Michael’s setting of one of Berry’s most beloved poems hangs in the air. It is as if Michael was reluctant to let any word fall unheard. The music so illuminates the emotional elements of the poem, that the words almost disappear into its sounds. The poem’s melancholy lives in the flute, whose obligato is always with us. Sustained chords in the choir slowly evolve as emotions migrate from heaviness to embodied peacefulness. Gradually the vocal melodies free into themselves. Layers become layers on layers until finally light pierces the haze. In the final phrase, the flute joins the voices, all are united in a new homophony, moving delicately together into the peace of wild things. Susan LaBarr chose an American musical signature in a pastoral theme set over lush, fifth-dominant harmonies in a pop-determinate chord progression. Like the others, her music is the essence of the poem. It’s the kind of music that makes you want to lie down in its sweetness and recall each moment you have most valued in life while experiencing this moment as one of them. Like Berry’s poem, LaBarr reminds us that this precious now is worth being with. It may be the only thing really worth being with, and that may be enough.” – Dr. David Harris